

these people trying to make a living, and with each person's profit being some other person's loss, this was no friendly business.

As to what I should do, Mr. Epstein said he'd definitely "go long" with Japanese yen if he were me, although being him he'd avoid trading anything at all. He also showed me an advisory bulletin published by Lind-Waldock, with one or two best bets of the day. The firm was recommending something called a deutsche-mark straddle—long the 48 call and short the 49 call simultaneously. From Mr. Epstein's explanation, I gathered that a straddle is roughly the same as arm-wrestling with yourself. Actually, he said I'd make money if the deutsche mark itself increased in value—but if it went up too much I'd lose.

Though Lind-Waldock hadn't mentioned pigs as a best bet, I told Mr. Epstein I'd always been fond of pigs, and therefore would prefer investing in a live hog option over the yen or the deutsche marks.

For further input, I made an appointment to see Ralph Silverstein, a veteran of the agricultural pits and a friend of a friend of the family. He had an office on an upper floor of the Chicago Board of Trade. As I waited in the anteroom, I heard several people whooping "New highs in the beans, new highs in the beans."

Mr. Silverstein was a pleasant, middle-aged man who no longer competed in the pits, and said he was happy to leave that ordeal to a younger crowd. Like many of the older traders, he'd moved upstairs to follow the action on computer screens. He was a confirmed wiggle-watcher, and got up several times during our interview to peer at the graphs on his monitor.

The same schism between Fundamentalists and Chartists exists in commodities as it does in stocks. Fundamentalists study weather reports, feedlot reports, silo utilization, grain sales, and so forth, while Chartists like Mr. Silverstein dispute the relevance of such facts and take their trading cues directly from squiggly lines. Minute to minute they watch their monitors, and in their spare time they pore over weekly charts collected in oversized binders, measuring peaks and valleys with their calipers the way sailors might lay out a course.

Soybeans were preoccupying Mr. Silverstein the day we talked, but I asked him about corn, since I'd eat corn over soybeans any